However, the most infamous lines of this interaction are the final words that Iqbal uttered just before Nehru left. ‘What is there in common between Jinnah and you? He is a politician, you are a patriot.’[3] Nehru understood this comparison as a double-edged compliment. In his self-deprecating manner, he readily acknowledged that he had never been ‘much of a politician’. Being a patriot alone, Nehru continued, would fall way short of his lifelong yearning to solve the problems ‘of the world as a whole’.[4]

Whether or not Iqbal truly shared Nehru’s passion for socialism or at any stage stopped advocating a separate Muslim homeland, he possessed a string of similarities with the Pandit. Both men had a refined taste for Indian and Western literature and philosophy. They were both of Kashmiri descent and never failed to portray the mountainous region in India’s north in the most glowing of terms in their writings and speeches.

Iqbal and Nehru were gifted orators and could keep large crowds enraptured for hours. While both liked to portray themselves as reluctant or even failed politicians, they were remarkably successful in their missions. Both men commanded the respect of their political cadres and were valued negotiators for their parties. When it was still uncommon for Indians to study abroad, Nehru and Iqbal attended the University of Cambridge and trained as barristers in London. They also shared a deep sense of empathy with the impoverished and backward sections of colonized people in India, and devoted their entire lives to stirring change in the material conditions of the poor.

They also saw eye to eye on several pressing questions in the international arena. For instance, both vehemently opposed ‘[t]he idea of a national home for the Jews in Palestine’. Iqbal saw the partition of Palestine as a ‘dangerous experiment’ and a sovereign state for Jewish people as a way for British imperialism to entrench itself ‘in the religious home of the Muslims’.[5] Nehru, ever the internationalist, regarded the Palestine question as a ‘gross betrayal of the Arabs’ and stood in solidarity with Arab nationalism’s ‘heroic fights for attaining independence’ from British imperialism.[6]